Heritage, Her-i-tage, and Hair-i-tage

By Adrienne Dawes

(Pg 91-98) *(REBEKAH, sixteen, confronts herself in the mirror. Mounds of bobby pins, barrettes, rubber bands, a variety of creams, oils, combs, brushes, and spray bottles litter the floor. REBEKAH attacks her mass of thick curls, running a huge comb through it awkwardly. Large clumps of curls fall around her. REBEKAH snatches them disgustedly.)*

REBEKAH: Eww ... nasty.

(REBEKAH throws the clumps away and returns to. the mirror. She waters her hair down with a spray bottle of moisturizer, then coughs loudly from the fumes. Determined, she dips her fingers into a huge jar of curl activator and glops it onto her scalp. Large puddles of golden glop fall around her. She begins to lose her patience as she tries to mold her goopy, damp hair into a ponytail.)

REBEKAH: *(on the verge of tears.)* Maybe I should just cut it all off!

(As REBEKAH reaches for a pair of scissors, loud sirens flare. Nap Patrol Officer (NPO) 1 enters stage left, dressed in a police uniform, her pressed hair greased and molded in an intricate bun on the top of her hair. Various black hair supplies hang from her belt like weapons. NPO 1 points a hair dryer at REBEKAH menacingly.)

NPO 1: Giiiirrrrl, I know you did not just say you wanted to cut your hair!!

REBEKAH: *(bewildered)* Who are you?

NPO 1: *(holding out a badge)* Nap Patrol Officer Shateequa Williams, Division 8, District 21.

INTRODUCTION

Despite the natural hair movement of the past decade which has led black and mixed-race women to abandon chemical straighteners, for some women, dealing with curly and tightly coiled hair feels like a daily chore. Mothers teach their daughter the best way to deal with this very specific type of hair . . . at least most mothers do. Not Rebekah's though. Rebekah has been left to figure it out for herself. That is . . . until the Nap Patrol arrives on the scene.

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NPO 1: How many times a week do you wash your hair? *(She carefully confiscates the scissors from REBEKAH)*

REBEKAH: Two, three times? Sometimes four if I have volleyball practice.

NPO 1: What in God's name are you trying to do to yourself? Didn't your mama teach you nothing

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about yo hair?

REBEKAH: *(quietly)* Uh, well . . . no. We're learning how . . .

NPO 1: Didn't nobody in your family ever learn you to take care of they hair?

REBEKAH: *(hesitantly)* Well, my mom is white and . . .

NPO 1: *(falls over in disbelief)* Oh, giiiiirrrrrrllll!!! *(into walkie-talkie.)* Jamilla? We've got ourselves a 911 sit-u-ation here. I need some backup pronto. Girlfriend needs a relaxer and some pink lotion ASAP!

NPO 2: *(offstage, on walkie-talkie.)* Why can't her mama do her hair like everybody else's?

NPO 1: Cuz her mama's white! *(NPO1 looks at REBEKAH sympathetically)* Bring some copies of ***Ebony*** for her too. The girl looks like she don't know nothing 'bout her heritage!

REBEKAH: Officer, I know about-

NPO 1: *(cuts her off)* Yeah, yeah, let me look at this hair . . . *(takes a huge clump of REBEKAH's hair in her hands, looking at each strand in amazement)* Just as I suspected . . . Your hair ain't never been relaxed or pressed before!

REBEKAH: The chemicals are disgusting and the heat will just make my hair frizzle. My mom told me that.

NPO 1: Your mama don't know nothin' about black hair! And apparently your daddy isn't around enough to make sure his child ain't cutting off a perfectly good head of hair!

(Sirens blare then cut off. NPO 2 rushes onstage, dressed in an identical uniform, her hair long, luxurious, and straight. She carries a box filled with beauty supplies and Ebony magazines, which she dumps in REBEKAH's lap.)

NPO 2: *(to NPO1, ignoring REBEKAH.)* I came as fast as I could. Some idiot threw his cigarette and it hit some poor brother's head, and sweet Jesus, it was all flames and fire and chaos! I had to perform an emergency Jeri curl revival! *(hands latex gloves to NPO1, then puts on a pair herself, moving to REBEKAH)* Okay, let's have a look. *(They pick through her hair roughly. REBEKAH winces.)*

NPO 1: *(in amazement.)* Raw hair-never had nothin' done to it. Feel how soft it is -- and thick! *(roughly pulls REBEKAH's hair. REBEKAH winces in pain)* Look, no dandruff or nothing!

NPO 2: *(to REBEKAH)* Sweetie, how old are you? *(astonished)* You never once thought in all those years to straighten your hair?

NPO 1: Her mama told her the chemicals were too harsh for her! *(They shake their heads and tsk in*

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disapproval. NPO 1 begins to straighten REBEKAH's hair)

NPO 2: Please! Your white mama told you nothing but lies. No chemical is too harsh. You just gotta grin and bear it, like the rest of us. 'Sides, it only burns if you scratch your scalp . . . *(suddenly suspicious)* Have you been scratching your scalp? *(The OFFICERS exchange a look.)*

NPO 1: *(cackling loudly)* Oh, giiirl, it's gonna burn! It's gonna burn, it's gonna burn like hell! You'll be all right, though, and you'll know for the next time-

NPO 2: *(matter-of-factly)* You gotta keep straightening the hair or it'll all break off and -- Oh, but it'll look so good, girl, it'll look pretty just like mine. Look at it. *(NPO 2 flips her greasy straightened hair over her shoulder and offers a strand for REBEKAH to inspect as she smiles at herself in the mirror)*

NPO 1: You see that? You'll look so pretty with hair like that-especially since yours is so long. All Jamilla has is a weave, her natural hair is only one inch long all around --

NPO 2: Now why did you have to go and tell her that?!

NPO 1: Well, it's true! *(aside to REBEKAH)* She looks like a sick porcupine without her weave-

NPO 2: Oh shut up, you're the one who had those ugly-ass braids in for like five years. Your hair line's receding too-gonna be bald before you're forty! *(the OFFICERS stand on either side of REBEKAH, ready to fight. REBEKAH has to push them apart)*

REBEKAH: Wait, wait, back to the part where my hair breaks off. How often do I have to get this done?

NPO 2: Only every six weeks-if you wanna keep it looking *good.* *(NPO1 scowls, walks over to REBEKAH again and looks at her hair)*

NPO 1: *(to NPO 2)* Mmm-e-relaxer's starting to take. It'll look so nice-especially since yours is au naturale! *(beat, to REBEKAH.)* 'Bout time you started looking like the rest of us! *(suddenly NPO 2's walkie-talkie beeps loudly.)*

VOICE ON WALKIE-TALKIE: *(Offstage.)* Jamilla, we got a messy Weave. Disaster spread across the Beautifully Black salon about two blocks from you! We need backup hair extensions, pronto! The beautician passed out from hair spray fumes and some of the women are about to leave the building without they weaves!

NPO 2: *(into walkie-talkie)* I'm on it. *(to the others)* I gotta go. See you around, Shateequa. You too, girl. You take good care of that hair of yours.

(NPO 2 runs offstage. Sirens blare, then fade into the distance. NPO1 paces behind REBEKAH, swinging her hair dryer. REBEKAH sits, reading the magazine and twitching.)

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NPO 1: *(smiling widely)* How you doin', girl?

REBEKAH: Uh . . . okay.

NPO 1: *(notices the page REBEKAH is reading)* That's Maya Angelou on that page there. She's a writer.

REBEKAH: *(dully)* Yes, I know who Maya Angelou is *(suddenly REBEKAH turns bright red. screaming)* FIRE!! FIRE!! MY SCALP IS ON FIRE!

NPO 1: *(groans)* Just keep it cool, girl. It'll be over in, like . . . *(checks her watch.)* Thirty minutes.

REBEKAH: THIRTY MINUTES?! I CAN'T WAIT THAT LONG. TAKE IT OFF! I'M GOING TO DIE! *(REBEKAH makes a lunge for her hair spray bottle. NPO1 quickly hits the bottle away, then· hauls REBEKAH back to her seat.)*

NPO 1: IT'S JUST A RELAXER. You're gonna be fine if you just shut up and sit down!! *(they struggle)*

REBEKAH: TAKE THE RELAXER OFF! TAKE IT OFF! I DON'T WANT STRAIGHT HAIR!

NPO 1: No! Now you are going to sit through it like everyone else, and you are going to be proud of your beautiful black hair-i-tagel

REBEKAH: AAAAAAAAHHHHHHHHH!

(sirens flash and NAP PATROL OFFICER I disappears, Lights darken around REBEKAH, who· has turned bright red, screaming and pulling at her hair. Smoke billows around her and swallows her. Blackout.)

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Adrienne Dawes
Book: Laugh Lines: Short Comic Plays, Pgs 91-98
ISBN: 978-0307277138
Publisher: Vintage
Date (Month/Year): April 2007

AWARD HISTORY

CA State Qualifier